

father did. As he says, “It gave me the satisfaction of knowing I was still useful to society, even though I was old and gray.”

Money Mistake: *You’re the Primary Caretaker for Your Parents*

The Fix: *Pay Yourself a Salary—You Deserve It*

Many Canadians today find themselves in the difficult position of being the primary caregiver for their ailing parents. If this describes you, you need to protect yourself and your family. First, go to your siblings and see if they are willing to donate time or resources. They may be able to help out so that the burden does not fall entirely on your shoulders. If you are an only child, however, or your siblings are unavailable (or unwilling) to assist you, I suggest you talk to your parents. Explain to them the costs of caretaking. You may have to quit your job or work shorter hours, which will necessarily affect your compensation. Make a financial arrangement with your parents to ensure that you are paid for your time.

If that makes you uncomfortable, get over it. Your parents are the last people in the world who would want to put you in a situation where you are working for no pay. If your parents are senile, just know that if they still had their wits about them, they would want you to put yourself and your own family first. That’s what they did with you, right?

Your parents may elect to compensate you for your time by giving you a bigger chunk of their inheritance once they pass. You’ll want to discuss that with them, too. Make sure everything is in writing, indisputably recorded in their will. Maybe you’ve got three brothers who haven’t lifted a finger while you’ve been breaking your back as a full-time caretaker. You’ve given your parents a tremendous gift. Do you deserve more money than your brothers? Sure you do. But the cold hard truth is that if your gift of time, love and resources is not reflected in your parents’ will, there is nothing you can do about it.

Julia, who is a friend of Linda’s and mine, is a high-powered professional whose mother is in a long-term care facility and needs